

Explain It Yourself — the only self-test you need

Recall facts won't help you in a conversation; being able to **explain an idea in your own words** will. For each prompt: look away, say it out loud as if to a friend, THEN check against the model. If you can't say it simply, you don't get it yet — go back to `1-UNDERSTAND-IT.md`. ~16 prompts. Do them out loud; that's the whole point.

Don't memorise the model answers. They're a *check*, not a script. If your version is different but means the same thing, you've got it.

- 1. What's the difference between consequentialism and deontology — and why does neither win?** *You've got it if you said something like:* Consequentialism says only outcomes matter — do whatever gives the best result. Deontology says some acts are wrong in themselves whatever the result. Neither wins outright: pure consequentialism would let you torture an innocent if it helped enough people; pure deontology can leave you letting a catastrophe happen just to keep your own hands clean.
- 2. What's the difference between *intending* a harm and *foreseeing* it — and who cares?** *Model:* Intending a harm means it's your aim or your means to your aim; foreseeing it means you know it'll happen but it's a side-effect you'd avoid if you could. Deontologists care a lot — it's the difference between murdering civilians and a strike that regrettably kills some.
- 3. Jus ad bellum vs jus in bello — what's each, and what's the trap?** *Model:* Ad bellum is about whether it's just to *go to war*; in bello is about whether you're *fighting* it justly. The trap is mixing them — they're independent, so a war can be just to start but fought with atrocities, or unjust to start but fought cleanly.
- 4. Why does this unit refuse to be relativist about war?** *Model:* Because if "it's all just opinion" were true, you couldn't actually say a massacre like My Lai was *wrong* — only that you dislike it. But we clearly can and do judge such things wrong, so some moral answers really are better than others.
- 5. What's the realist's claim, and what's wrong with it?** *Model:* The realist says morality doesn't apply to war — states just pursue power and survival. The catch: states often *do* act that way (true enough), but the moment you say they *should*, you're already making a moral claim — so morality sneaks back in.
- 6. What is the principle of distinction, and *why* are civilians immune?** *Model:* Distinction means you may target combatants but never deliberately target civilians. The deep question is *why* — innocence, harmlessness, or not being responsible for the threat — and "not responsible" is the strongest answer, which is why the hard cases (who counts?) get tricky.
- 7. What does proportionality ask you to weigh?** *Model:* That the good of an act has to outweigh the harm it causes — especially collateral harm to civilians. Two versions: the whole *war's* good vs its

harm (ad bellum — deciding to fight) and a single *strike's* gain vs its collateral (in bello — how hard you hit). It's the consequentialist *check* sitting alongside the deontological *limits*.

8. What does *mala in se* mean, and who can actually use the idea? *Model:* It means an act or weapon that's evil in itself — wrong by its very nature, not just by its effects (torture, rape, poison, arguably nuclear weapons). Only a deontologist can really say this; a pure consequentialist has no category for "evil-in-itself" because for them only outcomes count.

9. Explain the Doctrine of Double Effect — and its weak spot. *Model:* It says you may cause civilian deaths you *foresee* but don't *intend*, if they're a proportionate side-effect of a legitimate strike — but you may never make those deaths your aim or your means. The weak spot: "foreseen not intended" can be too convenient — you can't kill 50 civilians and just shrug "didn't mean to."

10. What's the "moral equality of combatants," and how does McMahan blow it up? *Model:* The traditional view (Walzer) is that all soldiers may kill each other regardless of whose cause is just — they're moral equals. McMahan says no: what makes you a target is *responsibility for an unjust threat*, so a soldier on the unjust side is more like an armed robber than an equal.

11. Define terrorism — and is it always worse than regular war? *Model:* Terrorism is deliberate violence against innocents to frighten or coerce a wider group — the wrong is targeting the innocent *on purpose*. Not obviously *always* worse: conventional war kills innocents too, so (Held's point) if we condemn terrorism for that, consistency means scrutinising "legitimate" war that does the same.

12. Why are nuclear weapons a special moral problem? *Model:* Because a strategic nuke is indiscriminate by its very nature — it incinerates a whole city, so it can't respect the civilian/combatant line (distinction), and its effects spill far beyond the target, so the harm can't be kept proportionate. That arguably makes it evil-in-itself and unusable within the rules of war.

13. What's the deterrence paradox? *Model:* Deterrence only works if your threat to annihilate enemy cities is *sincere* — so you have to genuinely intend to do something (mass murder of innocents) that it would be monstrous to actually do. The puzzle: can it be ethical to *threaten* what it would be unethical to *carry out*?

14. Is a drone "targeted killing" more like war or more like execution? *Model:* It sits in a grey zone — in war you may kill a combatant without trial, but in law enforcement you must arrest, not execute. The hardest version is the "signature strike," where you kill someone by their *behaviour pattern* without even knowing who they are.

15. What's the worry about "riskless" or asymmetric war? *Model:* When one side (a drone operator safe in a trailer) bears zero risk, war starts to look less like war and more like hunting — and you might ask whether killing keeps its moral seriousness when it costs you nothing. The counter: protecting your own troops is obviously a good thing, so why is safety a problem?

16. Explain Sparrow's responsibility gap — and Arkin's best reply. *Model:* With a truly autonomous weapon, no one can be fairly blamed when it kills wrongly — not the programmer (couldn't predict it), the commander (didn't decide it), or the machine (can't be punished) — and a

killing no one answers for is illegitimate. Arkin's reply: robots feel no fear or rage, so they might kill *fewer* civilians than panicked soldiers — in which case refusing to build them could be the worse choice. (Sparrow: better outcomes still don't fill the accountability gap.)

How to use this in your last day

Go through all 16 **out loud**, twice. The ones you fumble are your real revision list — everything else, leave alone. If you can talk through these sixteen, you can hold a conversation about anything in the unit.